

Waterloo Command

The Ridge and the Road

Original rules v1.1 • Two players • No dice

Command the French against Wellington's multinational Anglo-Allied army and the arriving Prussians. Move finished groups by hand, choosing formations, facing and when to spend scarce orders. Use the scenario sheets for setup and victory. The landscape compresses the relationships of the ridge, farms and eastern approach; it is not a survey map at the soldiers' scale. Rounds are not fixed historical minutes. Digital rules checks have been performed; physical handling, duration, enjoyment and balance await prototype play.

Your complete set

There are 20 combat units and three commanders. Twelve infantry units each contain four matching substands: 48 infantry pieces. Three cavalry, three guns, two skirmisher groups and three commanders bring the total to 59 movable miniature pieces. Keep an infantry unit's four stands together, including when stressed. Its ID matches its unit card. F identifies French, A Anglo-Allied and P Prussian; A and P are one coalition side. F5, the Imperial Guard, is the only elite unit.

Use the 20 unit cards with one square stress counter and one round activation counter per card, two order tracks and counters, and the round track and counter. A stress counter shows 0, 1 or 2; remove a unit when it would reach 3. Place an activation counter on the card after acting. Keep removed units together on the reserve apron with their card face down, separate from waiting Prussians. The scenery is fixed. No customer assembly is needed.

Cells, formations and facing

Files A–J run west to east. Ranks 1–7 run north to south; A1 is northwest. Adjacent means sharing an edge, never a corner. Distance is the number of horizontal plus vertical cell steps. One combat unit occupies a cell. Never move through occupied cells or swap units.

All units face north, east, south or west. Their front is the immediately adjacent cell in that direction; the other three adjacent cells are their two sides and rear. Turn the whole arrangement to its facing. Infantry line has four stands side by side; column has four stands one behind another; square has four outward-facing sides around an empty centre. Keep one nominated facing for a square's attacks; its other sides do not fire for free. Formations remain inside one logical cell. Place garrisons centrally in their clear courtyard. Lift by bases, not weapons or figures.

Commanders do not fight, occupy objectives, support attacks or block movement. They may share a friendly combat cell; place their marker beside that cell on a clear edge, never force overlapping pieces. They cannot enter an enemy combat cell. If an enemy enters their cell after its friendly defender

leaves, immediately relocate them to the nearest on-field friendly combat unit, ties by alphabetic file then lowest rank. If none remains, put them on the apron; this displaced commander returns beside the next friendly reinforcement to arrive. Displacement is free and compulsory, distinct from voluntary movement.

A round

1. Place scheduled reinforcements if their entry cell is empty.
2. Clear all activation counters. Reset each side's orders to its scenario allowance; unused orders never carry forward.
3. Alternate activations: French start odd rounds, coalition start even rounds. Spend the full action cost, mark every acting/supporting unit activated, and resolve immediately. A unit activates at most once per round. A side may permanently pass; its opponent then finishes alone. With no orders or unactivated on-field units, a side automatically passes. Passing forfeits remaining orders for that round.

4. After both sides finish, check the scenario's last-round victory condition or advance the round marker.

At the start of its first activation each round a side may relocate one on-field commander up to two orthogonal steps through friendly or empty cells, turning the route if desired. This is its sole voluntary free commander move: coalition chooses Wellington OR Blücher. Commanders ignore terrain movement restrictions and enemy adjacency but cannot cross enemy-occupied cells. Passing without any activation gives no free move. No reaction attacks or other free actions occur.

Actions

Unless stated, each action costs one order. Check terrain before moving. Advance, Withdraw, forced retreat and compulsory assault advance all obey entry restrictions. You cannot voluntarily choose an action you cannot pay for or complete legally.

Action	What happens
Advance	Move one orthogonal empty cell and choose facing. A square pays TWO orders; all other units pay one. Formation stays unchanged. Starting or ending beside an enemy is allowed.
Quick march	Column infantry, cavalry or skirmishers move exactly two empty cells in a straight orthogonal route, then choose facing and gain one stress. Illegal at stress 2, if either endpoint is adjacent to an enemy, or if either entered cell is a farm, village or rough terrain. The intermediate cell may be adjacent to an enemy; there are no reactions. May not cross the sunken lane.
Road march	Column infantry or artillery move exactly two empty cells north/south along file E, without stress. Apply Quick march's endpoint, entered-terrain and sunken-lane restrictions, but stress 2 is allowed because no stress is gained. Guns cannot Quick march.

Action	What happens
Reform	Infantry chooses line, column or square and any facing in its current cell, respecting that cell's formations. Other units just choose facing. Allowed adjacent to enemies.
Enter	TWO orders: infantry in an adjacent cell reforms to a formation permitted in an EMPTY farm/village, moves into it and chooses facing, as one activation. This does not attack an occupied farm.
Fire	Infantry or skirmisher attacks an enemy in its front-adjacent cell; artillery attacks the first enemy on its straight front ray, at range 1–3, if sight is clear. No movement or turning.
Assault	Infantry or cavalry attacks an enemy in its front-adjacent cell. No preliminary movement or turning. The attacker must already have a formation/type legal in the target cell. Guns and skirmishers cannot initiate an assault.

Action	What happens
Rally	Remove one stress when no enemy is adjacent and an on-field friendly commander is within two steps. Either coalition commander rallies either A or P. Illegal at stress 0; removed units never rally back.
Withdraw	Move one orthogonal empty cell, keep facing and gain one stress. The nearest enemy must be farther away after moving than before. Illegal at stress 2 or with no on-field enemy. Square costs one order for this specific action. Lane cavalry restrictions still apply.
Hold	Choose any facing, retain formation and stress, and stay put.

Terrain and sight

Place	Rule
Hougoumont B4; La Haye Sainte E3	Infantry in column or square, or skirmishers, only. No line. +1 defence against fire and assault.
Papelotte H3; Plancenoit H6	Infantry in COLUMN, or skirmishers, only. +1 defence against fire and assault. No square or line, even by Reform.
Orchard B5; woods J5-J7	No cavalry or artillery. Infantry may use any formation; skirmishers allowed. No marching through or into rough. +1 defence against fire only.
Ridge A2-H2	+1 defence against assault delivered from rank 3 directly south of the target. No bonus against fire or northern/side assaults.
Reverse slope A1-H1	Artillery in rank 3 or farther south cannot fire at these cells across the ridge. A gun in rank 2 may fire north normally.

Place	Rule
Sunken lane, A–H between ranks 1 and 2	No march crosses it. On any one-cell move across it cavalry gains one EXTRA stress, including Withdraw, retreat or assault advance. Cavalry at stress 2 cannot voluntarily cross; a forced retreat across removes it if the stress reaches 3. Other troops cross normally. No defence bonus.
Brussels road, file E	Road march rule above. E3 still blocks marching because it is a farm.
Belle Alliance E6; other fields and boundary hedges	Open ground; no extra modifier.

Defence terrain bonuses never add together: use at most +1. Sight is a cell rule, not a view along a miniature's barrel. Any intervening combat unit, farm/village cell, or ridge crossing from south to the reverse slope blocks artillery. Commanders, rough, fields, hedges and the inn do not block sight. A

farm may itself be the first target. All artillery rays are cardinal, never diagonal.

Resolve an attack

Find attack A and defence D; then apply modifiers. Values may be negative; do not clamp them.

Unit/formation	Fire A	Assault A	Base D
Infantry line	3	2	3
Infantry column	2	3	3
Infantry square	1	1	3
Cavalry	—	3	2
Skirmisher	2	—	2
Artillery	3 at range 1; 2 at range 2–3	—	2

Subtract attacker's stress from A and defender's stress from D. F5 gets +1 D against Assault only, not Fire. A square gets +2 D against cavalry Assault

only. A side/rear attack gives -1 D, except against square; use the attacker's direction relative to the defender's facing. Cavalry gets $+1$ A assaulting nonsquare infantry or skirmishers in open ground, including road or ridge; not farms/rough or against cavalry/guns. Add the applicable terrain defence.

You may spend ONE additional order to nominate ONE other unactivated friendly combat unit whose front-adjacent cell is the target. It contributes $+1$ A and becomes activated. It must have stress below 2. Infantry, skirmishers or artillery must be able to Fire at that target; cavalry must be able to Assault it legally. Such fire-capable units may support an Assault even though guns/skirmishers cannot initiate one. A supporter makes no separate attack and never moves, advances or suffers the attacker's failed-assault stress. An already activated unit cannot support. Support has no reaction or defence benefit.

A minus D	Fire	Assault
Below 0	No effect	Attacker gains 1 stress
Exactly 0	Defender gains 1 stress	Attacker gains 1 stress

A minus D	Fire	Assault
Exactly 1	Defender gains 1 stress	Defender gains 1 stress
2 or more	Defender gains 1 stress, then retreats	Defender gains 1 stress, then retreats

At stress 3 remove the unit immediately, before retreat. Otherwise retreat one cell directly AWAY from the attacker along the attack ray, retaining formation and facing. If occupied, off board or illegal for the defender, remove it; never select an alternative cell or push another unit. Retreat costs no orders and does not activate the defender. Apply lane stress if crossed. After an Assault vacates its target through removal or retreat, the attacker MUST enter that target, keep facing/formation, and apply lane stress if relevant. If that removes the attacker, leave the target empty. Fire and supporters never advance. Removal includes all four infantry substands. Resolve commander displacement after the movement.

End, reserves and reset

Immediate defeat occurs if a side has no on-field combat units and no scenario-scheduled pending reinforcements. Units excluded from a short scenario are not pending. Otherwise finish the fixed number of rounds, even if both pass or arrivals remain blocked. Objectives require a combat unit physically present at the final scoring instant; empty cells are uncontrolled. No remembered ownership. Apply the scenario's explicit win/draw rule. Rallies and repeated passes never extend a game.

For reset, clear all card counters, restore stress 0, reset round/orders and put the listed units in their scenario cells with the listed formation and facing. Put every excluded unit on the apron. To restore the display, use the main deployment; return P1, P2 and Blücher to their labelled reserve positions. Never combine deployments from different sheets.

Your illustrated first round

Follow the main setup. French begins round 1; each starts with six orders. Each numbered panel below is one activation; the first two are deliberately simple, then the central artillery duel shows why facing and support matter.

- 1. French foot approaches the orchard.** F1 moves B6 to B5, stays column, faces north. Advance costs one order: French 5. Place its activation counter. It gains no stress.
- 2. The farm fires.** A1 in B4 square facing south Fires at F1. $A=1$; $D=3+1$ orchard=4. Difference -3 : no effect. Coalition 5. Mark A1 activated.
- 3. The French battery changes position.** FG1 moves D5 to D4 and faces north. French 4. Its next-round sight to D3 is clear, but it cannot fire now.
- 4. Rifles face the approaching gun.** AS in D3 already faces south. Fire at FG1: $A=2$, $D=2$; a Fire tie gives the gun one stress. Coalition 4. Mark AS activated.

5. **The centre advances.** F2 moves E5 to E4 in column facing north. French 3. It is adjacent to La Haye Sainte but cannot attack until a later activation round.

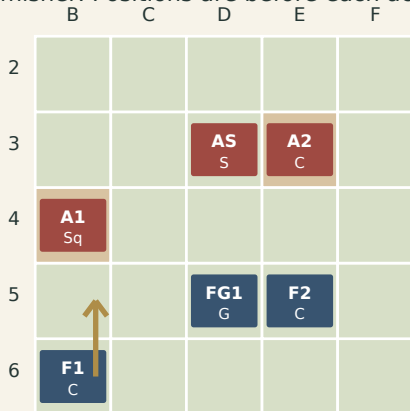
6. **The garrison holds.** A2 in E3 Holds facing south. Coalition 3. Keep it in column; line is illegal here.

7. Both players pass. Unspent three orders each are forfeited. Advance to round 2, clear activations and reset orders to six. Coalition starts. Decide whether to Fire, rally the gun after escaping adjacency, or reposition; the next round is unscripted.

Illustration key: the pictured panels show positions before each named action. Blue means French; red means coalition. Gold arrows show the movement or Fire named in the panel. Tan cells are farms. The diagrams are local board excerpts with selected units; use the setup table for the full deployment. Panels are instructional choices, not a recommended winning opening.

First round • pictured

Blue = French; red = coalition. C = column; Sq = square; G = gun; S = skirmisher. Positions are before each activation.



1 • F1 ADVANCES

B6 to B5

Column, facing north

French orders: 6 to 5

Local board excerpt; selected units shown.

	B	C	D	E	F
2					
3			AS S	A2 C	
4	A1 Sq				
5	F1 C		FG1 G	F2 C	
6					

2 · A1 FIRES

B4 to B5

A1 versus D4: no effect

Coalition orders: 6 to 5

Local board excerpt; selected units shown.

	B	C	D	E	F
2					
3			A5 S	A2 C	
4	A1 Sq				
5	F1 C		FG1 G	F2 C	
6					

3 · FG1 ADVANCES

D5 to D4

Gun faces north

French orders: 5 to 4

Local board excerpt; selected units shown.

	B	C	D	E	F
2					
3			AS S	A2 C	
4	A1 Sq		FG1 G		
5	F1 C			F2 C	
6					

4 • AS FIRES

D3 to D4

A2 versus D2: Fire tie

FG1 gains 1 stress

Local board excerpt; selected units shown.

	B	C	D	E	F
2					
3			A5 S	A2 C	
4	A1 Sq		FG1 G		
5	F1 C			F2 C	
6					

5 • F2 ADVANCES

E5 to E4

Column, facing north

French orders: 4 to 3

Local board excerpt; selected units shown.

	B	C	D	E	F
2					
3			AS S	A2 C	
4	A1 Sq		FG1 G	F2 C	
5	F1 C				
6					

6 · A2 HOLDS

E3, facing south

Column stays in farm

Coalition orders: 4 to 3

Local board excerpt; selected units shown.

Shape your infantry

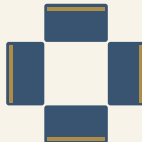
LINE



COLUMN



SQUARE



Four matching stands in every formation. Gold edge = facing.

Useful edge cases

- A cavalry Assault on a farm is illegal even if it would destroy the defender: cavalry could not enter afterwards.
- A supported line firing into a fresh farm square has A4 versus D4: the Fire tie adds stress. Farms and squares are strong, not immune.
- A fresh cavalry unit assaulting a fresh open square has A3 versus D5: the horse gains stress. That square still has ordinary defence against infantry and guns.
- An infantry line next to an occupied farm must Reform in a previous round before Assaulting; Enter only works into an empty cell.
- A unit can suffer attacks before or after its activation. Stress updates immediately. Retreat does not grant a new activation.
- If an arrival cell is occupied, wait until the next round's arrival phase, even if the cell empties later this round.

- A gun behind a friendly combat unit cannot fire through it. A commander alone does not block its ray.
- With one order left a square may Withdraw if legal, but cannot Advance or Enter. Support also requires the additional order before resolution.